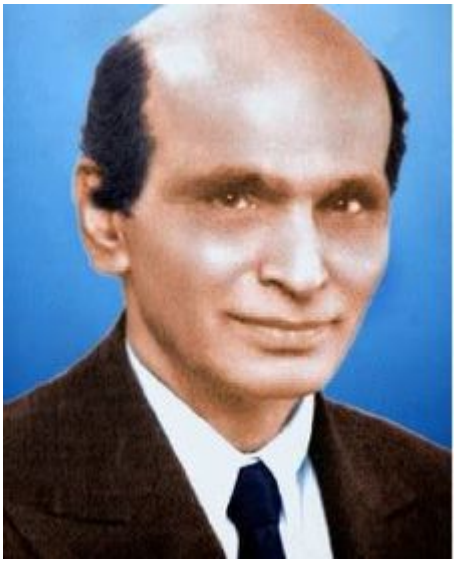
Gopalswamy Doraiswamy Naidu

G. D. Naidu (**Gopalaswamy Doraiswamy Naidu**) (23 March 1893 – 4 January 1974) was an Indian technical redesigner and industrial pioneer who transformed imported technologies into practical and affordable innovations for India. He is referred to as one of "the wealth creators of Coimbatore".[1] He is credited with the manufacture of the first electric motor in India. His contributions were primarily industrial but also spanned the fields of electrical, mechanical, agricultural (hybrid cultivation) and automobile engineering.[2][3] Naidu developed an independently internal combustion four stroke engine. He had only primary education but excelled as a versatile genius. He is also known as "Miracle Man".[4]

Gopalaswamy Doraiswamy Naidu



Gopalaswamy Doraiswamy Naidu

Born	23 March 1893 Kalangal, Coimbatore District, Madras Presidency, British India (now Tamil Nadu, India)
Died	4 January 1974 (aged 80) Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu, India
Citizenship	Indian
Known for	Technical redesigner, Industrialist, businessman, photographer and philanthropist
Scientific career	
Fields	Electrical, mechanics, automotive, agriculture

Personal life

G.D Naidu was born on 23 March 1893 in a Telugu agrarian family at Kalangal, Coimbatore, Madras Presidency, British India.[5] His childhood years were spent getting in trouble at school. He disliked attending All classes.

Early life

Naidu obtained work as a server in a hotel in Coimbatore with the intention of saving money to buy a motorcycle. After getting the vehicle he spent time dismantling and re-assembling it, and later became a mechanic. He began his transport business in 1920, with the purchase of an automobile coach. He drove it between Pollachi and Palani. In a few years, his Universal Motor Service (UMS) owned the most efficient fleet of public transport vehicles in the country.[6] In 1937, the first motor to be produced in India was brought out from G. D. Naidu's factory – NEW (National Electric Works) at Peelamedu, Coimbatore.

Technical redesigns and later life

Vehicle which Naidu purchased from the British and on which he learned assembling

G.D. Naidu developed India's first indigenous motor in 1937 along with D. Balasundaram Naidu. The motor's success resulted in the founding of Textool by D. Balasundaram Naidu (Popularly known as Textool Balasundaram) and, later, Lakshmi Machine Works (LMW).[7]

Naidu's 'Rasant' razor incorporated a small motor operated by dry cells, called Heilbronn.[7] Among his other inventions were super-thin shaving blades, a distance adjuster for film cameras, a fruit juice extractor, a tamper-proof vote-recording machine and a kerosene-run fan. In 1941, he announced that he had the ability to manufacture five-valve radio sets in India a mere ₹70/- a set. In 1952, the two-seater petrol engine car (costing ₹2000/-) rolled out. Production was stopped subsequently, because of the government's refusal to grant the necessary license. His inventiveness was not confined to machinery alone. He researched and identified new varieties in cotton, maize and papaya. His farm was visited by Sir C. V. Raman and Sir M. Visvesvaraya. From laying foundation to completion he built a house in just 11 hours, from 6am to 5pm.[3]

In 1922, he personally filmed the funeral of King George V in London. He met Adolf Hitler in Germany.[8] He invited K. Kamaraj to many functions. Among the Indian stalwarts that Naidu's camera captured were Mahatma Gandhi, Pandit Jawarharlal Nehru and Subhas Chandra Bose. Naidu remained an outsider to politics, despite having contested and lost in the 1936 provincial general elections. He was gifted a Rolls-Royce car and he was the only one who had this luxury car in those times.

3rd Prize for UMS Razor Company for razor blades in an exhibition in 1936 in Leipzig, Germany

In 1944, Naidu retired from active involvement with his automobile combine and announced several philanthropic measures including grants for research scholarships and welfare schemes for his employees and the depressed sections of society. In 1967, the G D Naidu Industrial Exhibition was established.

G.D. Naidu, Rathnasabapathy Mudaliar and India's first finance minister R. K. Shanmukham Chetty conducted survey, for bringing Siruvani water to the Coimbatore city.[9]

Through Naidu's efforts and donations India's first polytechnic college, the Arthur Hope Polytechnic and the Arthur Hope College of Engineering were set up. Later the college moved to its present location and is now known as Government College of Technology (GCT). The college was named after the then Madras governor Arthur Hope. In 1945, GD Naidu was the principal of the college.[10] Naidu was not satisfied with the four-year programs and said that it was a waste of time for students. He suggested that

two years was more than enough to teach the same courses, even with different concentrations. However, the British government did not accept his idea and Naidu resigned from his post.[11] The name Hope College for the original site of the college remains in Coimbatore even now.

Naidu died on 4 January 1974. Sir C V Raman said of Naidu: "A great educator, an entrepreneur in many fields of engineering and industry, a warm-hearted man filled with love for his fellows and a desire to help them in their troubles, Mr Naidu is truly a man in a million – perhaps this is an understatement!" He is survived by his son G.D. Gopal and grandchildren G.D. Rajkumar and Shantini. A permanent Industrial Exhibition in his memory is in Coimbatore. He provided employment in the engineering and manufacturing sectors to many individuals in the 1950s and 1960s.

Legacy

G. D. Matriculation Higher Secondary School and G. D. Public School in Coimbatore are named after him.[12]

His biography *Appa* as written by the popular Tamil writer Sivasankari.[13]

In popular culture

GD Naidu – The Edison of India is a documentary film, directed by K. Ranjit Kumar and produced by the Films Division of India, covering his life, times and contributions. It won the Best Science & Technology Film Award at the 66th National Film Awards.[14]

GDN is a film, directed by Five Star Krishna covering his life, times and contributions is being produced in which R. Madhavan plays the role of Naidu. [15]

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External links

- G.D.Naidu Museum & Industrial Exhibition in Coimbatore (http://www.destinationinfinity.org/2011/01/02/g-d-naidu-museum-industrial-exhibition-in-coimbatore/)
- Vintage cycle at G.D. Naidu Museum, *The Hindu* (http://www.thehindu.com/todays-paper/tp-features/tp-editorialfeatures/article1453197.ece?viewImage=5)

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